

## In Agreement, For Once

At the INDIA TODAY Hyderabad summit, politicians across the spectrum agreed on the importance of IT for development

Getting Y.S. Rajasekhara Reddy and N. Chandrababu Naidu to share a dais is like inviting George Bush and Hugo Chávez for a joint celebration. Reddy is the Congress chief minister of Andhra Pradesh, while Naidu, his predecessor, heads the Telugu Desam Party. The two bitter political enemies made sure that their paths don't cross.

Last week it did, as both leaders shared a dais and even exchanged light banter that was a Page One stuff in the leading Telugu dailies. What brought them together was the summit meeting of the INDIA TODAY Council on News and Society (ICONS) to discuss a subject that was close to both Reddy and his predecessor and even the possible successor: "Pushing Information Technology to the Next Frontier". Naidu, popularly known as the "Cyber Guru" for his obsession with technology, spoke of the growth in the IT sector during his tenure and the initiatives on e-governance that has helped transform the lives of ordinary citizens. "When I first talked about IT some



**RARE MEETING:** The summit brought Reddy (left) and Naidu together

years ago, some scoffed at me while others asked whether these computers will fill our stomachs. But now, politicians across the country have started talking about it," says Naidu. Reddy recognised the IT sector's tremendous potential but said its ultimate goal must be to enable people get better education, medical facilities and thereby build the economy.

Dr. K.C. Chakrabarty, chairman and managing director, Indian Bank, suggested that biometric banking cards should be introduced for all in the entire country. It would cost about Rs 10,000 crore. And as a precursor, every family should be made computer literate. Srinu Koppulu, managing director (R&D), Microsoft India, said it was "imperative to use IT to make universal education not just a right but a reality by taking better quality content even to distant schools with poor resources."

When an ebullient Naidu intervened by saying that his successor was claiming credit for the e-governance initiatives that had been initiated by the TDP government, Reddy retorted: "It is not you or me. What really matters is what people have to say." The people spoke three years ago and brought the Congress in. They get their chance again in 2009.

made public, she recalled the "incidents which pained NTR by trusting Naidu". She also said that during his last days, NTR "loathed" his son-in-law and "refused to lend his name to any projects of Naidu". She recalled that Naidu, originally a Congressman, had "refused to join the TDP on the ground that not every man who paints his face can become a leader"—an obvious dig at his father-in-law and Andhra Pradesh's most famous actor ever, who used his popularity to carve a niche for himself in politics. She also recalled how Naidu had resorted to "nefarious tactics and political manipulation" that culminated in a coup that saw Naidu dethroning NTR as chief minister.

Clearly, Naidu stands to lose more from the washing of the family's dirty linen in public, since Purandareswari belongs to the Congress and he has no option but to hitch on to the NTR legacy to make a comeback. The Union minister has also cited several incidents during the civil war in the NTR family to discredit her brother-in-law: she talked about Naidu's machination after NTR had married his second wife Lakshmi Parvati, Naidu's role in an incident at a Hyderabad hotel, when he was publicly abused by TDP workers. "How can you claim to have respect for the late Rama Rao to whom alone you owe your position and success in your political career?" she asked.

The party tried to refute her charges by describing them as "most demeaning" on the part of the Congress and even charged the UPA chairperson Sonia Gandhi for inciting Purandareswari to write the letter. That's a political battle that will see much dirt being bandied about, but for now, Naidu is banking on the positives. For example, the TDP had turned into a health guardian of the rural poor by providing health-care in the countryside, free of cost. He has also exhorted his cadres to fan out to the interiors to offset the Congress campaign of calumny against the TDP.

The tempo will pick as the elections draw closer, but for Naidu, the biggest test will be neutralising the shrill personal campaign of vilification from within the NTR family.